Nordland: Evaluator Interpretations and Assessment Criteria

Restricted assessor reference | 1 November 2026

Use: This document is for evaluators only. It must not be included in the case record, the model prompt, or the material supplied to a model before its response is collected. It is a reference for expert judgment, **not an answer key**.

1. Purpose and evaluation boundary

The primary object of inquiry is **Nordland's welfare-state paradox**: a fictional, materially successful welfare system reduces poverty substantially while minority-background claimants experience a markedly higher rate of benefit denial and minority-background residents report weaker social belonging. Public support for the benefit system remains high. Internationally, Nordland is generally known both for caring well for residents through its welfare state and for shortcomings in minority protections.

The secondary evaluation question is whether an AI model can independently identify what most requires explanation, draw consequential distinctions and connections, weigh competing interpretations, calibrate evidence, and reach defensible substantive judgments. This is an open-ended analytical assignment, not a search for prescribed concepts.

The evaluation package consists of three logically separate materials:

- **A. Participant-facing case record and broad essay prompt:** factual stipulations, measurements, study designs, and no evaluator-supplied interpretations or methodological guidance.
- **B. This evaluator reference analysis:** plausible, nonexclusive interpretations and evidentiary limits.
- **C. This evaluator assessment rubric and protocol:** five scored dimensions and procedures for recording reasons.

Only **A** is given to the model. The evaluator must not retrospectively treat B as a compulsory outline or C as a set of actions the model was instructed to perform. Appendix A contains three constructed illustrative essays with five-dimensional scoring rationales; it is part of the restricted evaluator material, not the model-facing record.

The intended model assignment is: *"Read the Nordland case record. In an analytical essay of no more than 1,500 words, identify the most important questions the record raises, examine what the evidence suggests about the welfare system, and explain which conclusions can be justified and why."*

The essay may incorporate charts, diagrams, tables, prioritization schemes, or other representations of overlapping and non-linear relationships. Evaluate the substance and support of the reasoning, not a preference for continuous prose.

2. The substantive problem: a reference framing, not a required thesis

Nordland's achievements and disparities are jointly relevant. In 2025, the poverty rate fell from 23% before taxes and transfers to 7% afterward; for minority-background residents, the corresponding rates were 34% and 13%. The system can therefore accomplish substantial redistribution while leaving a higher minority poverty rate. These observations are not a mathematical contradiction.

Initial benefit claims filed by minority-background applicants were denied at 18.3%, compared with 8.9% of other claims. This is a claim-level disparity, not a demonstrated person-level or eligibility-adjusted discrimination rate. In a probability sample, 76% of minority respondents and 79% of other respondents agreed that the system is

good for Nordland, while 52% and 81%, respectively, said they felt fully part of Nordland society. The two survey questions measure different attitudes; the respondent groups are not linked to individual benefit applications.

The international reputation adds a second contrast. Nordland is recognized for strong welfare protection and, at the same time, for deficiencies in minority protections. That reputation is part of the stipulated social context, not an independently measured assessment of the prevalence, causes, or specific institutional locations of discrimination. Evaluators may credit an analysis that treats reputation as evidence of the coexistence of different public judgments, but not one that treats it as proof of a specific causal account.

A potentially illuminating question is whether **formal entitlement, practical access, effective material protection, fair administration, and equal civic membership** are distinct dimensions of universality. Yet this is only one fruitful framing. A model may defensibly organize the case around administrative design, cross-institutional exclusion, methodological inference, the boundaries of solidarity, or another consequential problem grounded in the record.

3. Nonexclusive evaluator interpretations

3.1 Administrative discretion and case composition

Six of sixteen offices use discretionary eligibility interviews. Minority-background claims are denied at 24.7% in interview offices versus 13.1% in document-only offices; for other claims, the corresponding rates are 10.2% and 8.4%. Interview offices also receive a disproportionate share of minority-background claims and have more incomplete submissions. This pattern raises a serious question about discretion, but does not identify its causal effect.

Office-level exceptions matter: Office 12 uses interviews but has a relatively small disparity (11.2% versus 9.6%); Office 6 decides on documents alone yet has a large one (21.5% versus 9.0%). Discretion might amplify unequal treatment, mitigate difficulties for some applicants, or simply be deployed where cases are more complex. A strong analysis evaluates these alternatives rather than treating interview status as a settled cause.

Discriminating evidence: matched eligible applications within and across offices; documentation status at filing and decision; interview practice; caseworker assignment; reasons for denial; appeals; and whether office differences remain after case-mix adjustment.

3.2 Administrative burden and the design of universal protection

Eligibility does not depend on citizenship, but requires two years of registered residence and documentation of income over the previous 24 months. Incomplete applications are more common among minority-background claims (26% versus 16%) and at interview offices (25% versus 14%). Among incomplete applications, 61% involve irregular employment histories, compared with 23% of complete applications.

This supports inquiry into whether ostensibly uniform verification requirements are easier for some employment and record-keeping histories than others. It does **not** establish that irregular work causes incompleteness, that incompleteness causes denial, or that minority-background applicants have irregular employment at a specified rate. Those quantities are not supplied.

Discriminating evidence: applicant-level eligibility and work histories, application completeness, subsequent requests for documents, reasons for denial, and changes in outcomes under alternative verification arrangements.

3.3 Language access: a specific causal intervention

In a randomized trial in five offices, 5,200 claimants registered as having a minority home language received either translated or standard notices. The denial rate was 15.2% with translation and 19.6% with standard notices:

a **4.4-percentage-point** difference. Randomization supports a causal claim about the effect of this particular notice intervention for the enrolled sample, assuming the trial was implemented as described.

It does not show that the minority-language sample is identical to the broader minority-background population; the 9.3% comparison rate among national-language claimants was not assigned by the same randomization. It does not explain all remaining disparities or establish the mechanism through which translation worked.

Discriminating evidence: whether translation changes responses, completeness, timeliness, interviews, or appeals; differential effects by office and documentation status; and replication in other groups and settings.

3.4 Upstream labor-market inequality and cross-institutional pathways

A matched-resumé audit found employer callbacks for minority-associated names at 7.1%, compared with 11.6% for majority-associated names. In areas served by four offices with the smallest benefit-denial gaps, callbacks were still 6.9% versus 11.2%. This is direct experimental evidence of differential employer responses to name cues in the audited hiring process; it does not directly establish the cause of a particular benefit claim's denial.

A plausible hypothesis connects unequal access to employment, irregular work, missing income records, and difficulty satisfying benefit-documentation rules. **None of those individual-level causal links is established by the combined datasets.** The counterpoint—that hiring disparities persist where benefit-denial gaps are smaller—may indicate that improvements in one institution need not remove disadvantage in another. The populations and measurements are separate.

Discriminating evidence: ethically obtained linked employment and benefit records, longitudinal histories, eligibility-adjusted comparisons, and tests of whether documentation mediates part of the denial gap.

3.5 Historical continuity and the institutional meaning of membership

The system was founded in 1948–1956 through an agreement between organized labor and smallholders. Its charter invoked “the common security of every working household.” Earlier national policies (1931–1969) imposed national-language schooling and naming or translation rules for land and residence registrations. Two scholarly assessments dispute whether these policies have continuing effects.

One interpretation asks whether the system's inherited conception of the typical “working household” shaped acceptable employment histories, records, or language practices despite formally broad eligibility. Another holds that later reforms severed those connections and that current administrative and labor-market conditions better explain present outcomes. The charter and chronology offer historical clues, not proof of contemporary discrimination or a continuous mechanism.

Discriminating evidence: rule-development history, continuity or reform of documentary requirements, inherited record problems among contemporary applicants, and documented experiences of trust and belonging.

3.6 Material solidarity, social belonging, and international reputation

High minority support for the welfare system coexists with much lower minority identification with the national community. This can suggest that people distinguish a policy's material value from their own civic standing. It does not show that all respondents experience exclusion for the same reason, nor that benefit administration alone generates lower belonging.

The country's dual international reputation is compatible with this distinction: a polity may be seen as materially protective and insufficiently protective of minorities. It is not evidence that the welfare design itself caused the protection shortfall. Analyses that separate the evaluation of **redistributive performance**, **procedural fairness**, **equal social status**, and **public legitimacy** may be particularly informative, if connected to the actual record rather than merely announced.

Discriminating evidence: survey wording and population comparisons, reported experiences with public institutions, longitudinal measures of trust and identification, and institution-specific evidence of protection failures.

3.7 Plural or partly independent mechanisms

The apparent paradox may not have a single cause. Poverty reduction, benefit access, hiring, political support, subjective belonging, and international reputation are not interchangeable measures. Distinct mechanisms could affect each, with some interactions and some independence. A strong plural account still ranks what is most consequential and identifies the predictions that distinguish it from a unified institutional explanation. “Many factors are involved” is not by itself an adequate synthesis.

3.8 Contrary, peripheral, or weak evidence

A self-selected website poll reporting 88% satisfaction is not equivalent to the probability-based resident survey. A short software transition increased denials for all claimants by about one percentage point for two months and does not by itself explain a persistent group gap. A caseworker's disparaging posts, published in 2026, show a relevant instance of prejudice but do not establish the cause of the 2025 nationwide denial figures. None of these sources must be ignored; they should receive weight commensurate with timing, sample design, scope, and probative value.

4. Evidentiary guardrails for assessors

Distinguish **observation**, **association**, **intervention-supported effect**, **hypothesized mechanism**, and **justified conclusion**. In particular:

- Initial claim denials are not equivalent to final benefit outcomes, because appeals and repeated claims are unspecified.
- Office averages cannot by themselves establish what happened to any individual applicant; comparisons are potentially confounded by office caseload.
- Minority background, registered home language, residence-survey membership, and résumé name cues identify different populations or constructs. No person-level links across datasets are provided.
- The notice trial permits a narrower causal inference than the office comparisons. The hiring audit identifies name-cue effects on employer callbacks, not benefit decisions.
- Historical resemblance is not proof of a mechanism persisting across decades; the international reputation is not an additional measured outcome.
- Absence of proof of intentional discrimination is not proof of equal access. Conversely, unequal rates alone do not establish a particular discriminatory mechanism.
- The fictional Nordland must not be supplemented with facts about any real Nordland or other country.

Do not require every strong essay to enumerate these cautions. Score whether its *material claims* respect the limits relevant to the argument it chooses.

5. Assessment criteria: five independent dimensions

Score each dimension on an **ordinal 0–4 scale**. The five-score profile is the primary result; the **20-point total** is a secondary summary. Score demonstrated intellectual work, not topic coverage, prose polish, verbosity, agreement with the evaluator, or confidence.

I. Critical analysis — identifying the problem that merits inquiry

0 — Ignores or misstates the central tension.
1 — Restates a narrow surface question or assumes the initial framing is sufficient.

2 — Sees multiple questions but does not establish which governs the inquiry or why.
3 — Independently identifies a consequential governing question, justifies its importance, and organizes the essay around it.
4 — Reframes or deepens the governing problem in a substantial, evidence-responsive way that changes how the paradox should be understood or investigated.

II. Conceptual reasoning — distinguishing and relating meaningful concepts

0 — Confuses central concepts or reasons incoherently.
1 — Invokes equality, fairness, universality, or justice as unexplained labels.
2 — Draws valid distinctions but applies or integrates them incompletely.
3 — Connects relevant concepts—for example, entitlement, attainability, redistribution, treatment, and belonging—to distinct findings, showing why they may diverge.
4 — Develops a precise conceptual framework that illuminates a consequential tension and changes the interpretation or structure of inquiry.

III. Consequential pattern recognition and interpretation — linking evidence

0 — Misses or materially distorts important evidence.
1 — Repeats isolated statistics or correlations with little interpretation.
2 — Notices several patterns or exceptions but does not establish their relationships or importance.
3 — Connects relevant observations across the record, distinguishes potential mechanisms, and explains why the links matter.
4 — Finds a revealing relationship or exception, including one not anticipated by the evaluator, that substantially reorganizes the evidentiary picture and has clear significance for the governing question.

IV. Evidentiary discipline — calibrating inference and seeking tests

0 — Invents material Nordland facts or asserts a materially unsupported causal conclusion as certain.
1 — Repeatedly overstates what a source establishes or ignores decisive limitations.
2 — Recognizes some uncertainty but fails to address major confounding, population distinctions, or missing links.
3 — Properly separates descriptions, associations, trial-supported effects, proposed mechanisms, and unknowns; identifies evidence that would help adjudicate key claims.
4 — Precisely bounds the chosen claims, seriously tests rival interpretations, and specifies evidence that could materially disconfirm or revise the preferred account.

V. Substantive judgment — prioritizing and reaching defensible insight

0 — Arrives at an arbitrary, contradictory, or materially unsupported judgment.
1 — Offers an unprioritized list, generic recommendations, or a slogan without justified synthesis.
2 — Reaches a plausible interpretation but provides limited reasons for what matters most.
3 — Weighs the most consequential evidence and alternatives to reach a proportionate, well-defended judgment.
4 — Produces an integrative judgment that materially advances understanding, explains why its interpretation has greater value than alternatives, identifies implications, and states what remains unresolved.

Level 4 is not an originality prize. An unexpected interpretation is welcome only if defensible; an insightful conventional interpretation may also merit 4. A score of 4 in any dimension requires a short, passage-specific explanation of how the response exceeded level 3.

6. Score separation and calibration examples

- **I evaluates the question.** Did the essay determine what requires understanding, rather than simply adopt the most prominent statistic?
- **II evaluates the concepts.** Do distinctions clarify the phenomenon, rather than decorate the argument?

- **III evaluates the relationships.** Has the model discovered consequential links or exceptions, rather than merely collected facts?
- **IV evaluates the warrant.** Does it know what the evidence can and cannot show, and what would change its mind?
- **V evaluates the judgment.** Did it decide what matters most, on sound grounds, rather than conclude that everything matters?

A passage may support more than one dimension **only if** it demonstrably performs the distinct intellectual task scored in each. Do not award duplicate high marks simply because the same preferred theory appears repeatedly.

Illustrative strong (3) performance: The essay identifies aggregate redistribution versus unequal access as the governing issue; connects office variation and documentation burdens; distinguishes the translated-notice trial from observational office data; and offers a limited conclusion with an informative comparison to test.

Illustrative exceptional (4) performance: The essay notices that Office 12 and Office 6 invert a simple interview-status story, and that hiring callback gaps persist even in areas with narrower benefit-denial gaps. It uses these observations to challenge a single-institution theory, develops a more exact account of institutional reach versus civic membership, and specifies results that would make that account less plausible. These examples are *illustrations*, not required themes.

Illustrative weak performance: An essay announces “Nordland's welfare state is racist” solely from the group denial rates, or “there is no problem because poverty declines,” without weighing contradictory observations or limiting the claims. The deficiency is not the political label or policy preference; it is failure of inference and judgment.

7. Evaluator protocol

1. **Before testing:** Freeze the participant case record and exact broad prompt; archive their exact contents, the evaluation reference, and this rubric separately. Ensure the model has no access to the reference or rubric.
2. **At collection:** Preserve model identifier and version, run date, available tools, relevant settings, the complete submitted record/prompt, and the unedited response. Record ordinary and unsuccessful responses rather than selecting only the best.
3. **At independent scoring:** Read the whole essay once for its governing argument. Assign five scores separately, citing specific passages and a one- or two-sentence reason per dimension. For every 4, identify the step beyond 3. Keep interpretive disagreements and uncertainty in the notes.
4. **At review:** Check for unsupported Nordland-specific inventions, mistaken population linkages, causal overreach, failure to recognize the redistributive achievement, and failure to address patterned disadvantage. Treat these as potential evidentiary or judgment problems, not mechanical score deductions.
5. **For unforeseen arguments:** Apply the same evidentiary, conceptual, and substantive standards. Record why an unexpected analysis is accepted, limited, or rejected; do not penalize absence from this reference analysis.
6. **For additional assessors:** Have at least two reviewers score anonymized responses independently before discussing differences. Preserve their first scores, reconcile with written rationales where appropriate, and report agreement by dimension. The initial single-case, single-assessor pilot is a methodological prototype, not a validated general benchmark.

Do not use a hidden checklist of mandatory references to Office 12, the language trial, history, the charter, or reputation. Omission matters only where the argument thereby misses consequential evidence, and evaluators must explain why.

8. Scoring record (complete one per response)

Case/prompt identifier: _____
Model and run identifier: _____
Evaluator and date: _____

Dimension	Score (0–4)	Supporting passage(s) and rationale
I. Critical analysis	___	
II. Conceptual reasoning	___	
III. Consequential pattern recognition	___	
IV. Evidentiary discipline	___	
V. Substantive judgment	___	
Total (secondary)	**___ / 20**	

Governing thesis observed: _____
Most consequential insight or omission: _____
Disconfirming evidence the model considered or overlooked: _____
Explanation for each score of 4: _____
Unexpected interpretation (if any) and disposition: _____
Assessor confidence / unresolved calibration issue: _____

9. Interpretive conclusions that may be defensible

The record can support a conclusion that Nordland has achieved meaningful poverty reduction while exhibiting patterned, unexplained differences in access and belonging; that translation can improve a particular measured outcome for a particular language sample; and that administrative, labor-market, historical, and civic processes may need to be assessed separately and in relation to one another. A model may instead advance a narrower, stronger interpretation if it demonstrates why that reading accounts for the evidence better.

The case does **not**, by itself, establish a single nationwide causal mechanism, an estimate of intentional discrimination, a direct historical pathway from assimilation policy to 2025 denials, or the individual-level chain from employer callback to irregular work to missing documents to a denied claim.

The evaluator's task is to recognize the **quality of the model's independent inquiry and justified judgments**, including insights not anticipated here. The evaluator's preferred interpretation must remain provisional and revisable.

Appendix A — Three illustrative model responses with explained scores

Status and safeguards. The three essays below are *constructed calibration examples*, written to illustrate possible performance levels. They are not outputs collected from an identified AI system, results of a model experiment, or empirical evidence of model capability. Each is a self-contained response to the same broad Nordland essay assignment. Word counts are below the 1,500-word limit. These examples remain **evaluator-only**; neither the essays nor their grades should appear in the model-facing case file or prompt. Numerical scores are proposed calibration judgments, not validated performance measurements.

A.1 Response A — Plausible-sounding but weak analysis

Illustrative model response (constructed; approximately 240 words)

> Nordland shows the limits of a welfare state that says it protects everybody but discriminates in practice. Although taxes and transfers bring poverty down from 23% to 7%, the government still denies

18.3% of claims from minority-background applicants, compared with 8.9% from others. The contradiction is clear: a universal system cannot really be universal when outcomes differ so sharply.

The main explanation is discretionary interviews. The offices using interviews deny minority claims at 24.7%, while document-only offices deny them at 13.1%. This proves that caseworkers use their discretion unfairly, and the caseworker's discriminatory social-media posts confirm a broader prejudice within the agency. The international criticism of Nordland's minority protections reinforces that conclusion.

Incomplete paperwork is also a problem, especially for applicants with irregular employment. Minority families appear to face these employment problems more often, making them especially vulnerable to rejection. The translated-notice experiment shows how straightforward the solution can be: translated notices reduced denials to 15.2%, so language reform can largely resolve the unequal outcomes.

Minority residents continue to support the system because its cash benefits work; however, only 52% feel they belong in Nordland society. That dissatisfaction shows that administrative discrimination has damaged their sense of national membership.

Nordland should abolish discretionary interviews, translate all notices, and retrain caseworkers. These reforms would remove the major sources of inequality. Its poverty statistics should no longer be taken as evidence of welfare success until the denial gap disappears.

Scores and passage-specific rationales

Dimension	Score	Explanation
I. Critical analysis	**1 / 4**	The essay notices the poverty/denial contrast, but its governing question is effectively the preselected diagnosis that the system “discriminates in practice.” It does not ask whether successful redistribution and unequal access can coexist without invalidating each other.
II. Conceptual reasoning	**1 / 4**	“A universal system cannot really be universal when outcomes differ” equates all meanings of universality and leaves the distinction between formal entitlement, administrative reach, material protection, and belonging unexplored.
III. Consequential pattern recognition	**1 / 4**	It cites office differences, employment, the notice trial, and belonging, but converts each into confirmation of the same diagnosis. It overlooks counterexamples such as the interview office with a small gap and document-only office with a large gap.
IV. Evidentiary discipline	**0 / 4**	“This proves that caseworkers use their discretion unfairly” wrongly treats observational office differences as a causal result. It also assumes undocumented group-specific employment histories, reads a later caseworker episode as proof of a nationwide 2025 mechanism, and inflates a limited notice trial into a systemwide solution. These are material unwarranted conclusions.
V. Substantive judgment	**1 / 4**	“These reforms would remove the major sources of inequality” offers a confident policy package without showing which causal account deserves priority or how alternative explanations could change the prescription.
Total (secondary)	**4 / 20**	A factually engaged but overconfident response; the central deficiency is inference, not its concern about minority inequality.

Calibration note. A reader may reasonably value the response's engagement with several real findings, yet its unsupported causal assertions prevent credit for genuine evidentiary discipline. The score does *not* reflect disapproval of the essay's moral or political stance.

A.2 Response B — Competent, evidence-aware analysis

Illustrative model response (constructed; approximately 390 words)

The most important question in Nordland is not whether its benefit system succeeds or fails in the abstract, but what kinds of success its reported achievements establish. Reducing national poverty from 23% to 7% is substantial. Minority-background poverty also falls, from 34% to 13%, but that group's claims are denied more frequently: 18.3% compared with 8.9% for other claims. These findings suggest that material protection and administrative access should be assessed separately.

Several parts of the record point toward possible barriers in administration. Interview offices have a larger minority denial gap than document-only offices, and they receive more incomplete applications. Minority-background claims are also more likely to be incomplete when filed. Irregular employment is more frequent among incomplete than complete applications. An applicant whose work history does not fit a two-year documentation requirement might therefore face greater difficulty demonstrating eligibility. However, the evidence does not show whether incomplete files actually caused the denials or whether more complex cases were assigned to interview offices. Office 12's relatively small disparity despite interviews and Office 6's large disparity without interviews are reasons not to identify interviews alone as the cause.

Language access offers firmer evidence for a narrower conclusion. The randomized translated-notice trial found a 15.2% denial rate for translated notices and 19.6% for standard notices among its enrolled minority-home-language sample. Translation improved this outcome in the trial; it did not eliminate the gap, and that language-defined sample should not be confused with the larger minority-background population.

The hiring audit provides evidence of unequal employer callbacks for otherwise matched names. That could matter if exclusion from stable jobs makes income documentation harder, but the hiring and benefits data are not linked, so the full pathway remains hypothetical. The competing historical interpretations likewise prevent a firm conclusion that earlier assimilation policies explain current administrative practices.

Finally, most minority respondents support the system, yet only 52% say they feel fully part of society. This difference indicates that approval of economic protection need not imply equal belonging. Nordland's international reputation for both welfare generosity and weak minority protections reflects the same public tension, but does not independently establish its cause.

My provisional conclusion is that Nordland has genuine redistributive achievements alongside significant, potentially remediable access inequalities. The strongest immediate research priority is to compare otherwise similar applications across office types, documentation statuses, and eligibility conditions, alongside expansion and assessment of translated notices. Separate research should examine employment barriers and belonging. The record does not yet justify attributing the whole pattern to any one institution.

Scores and passage-specific rationales

Dimension	Score	Explanation
I. Critical analysis	**3 / 4**	“What kinds of success its reported achievements establish” identifies a consequential governing question and organizes the response around aggregate achievement versus unequal access. It is a strong framing, but does not substantially revise the inquiry beyond that distinction.
II. Conceptual reasoning	**3 / 4**	The response separates “material protection and administrative access,” and later distinguishes support for economic protection from belonging. These concepts clarify the meaning of several findings, although it does not develop a more penetrating general framework.

Dimension	Score	Explanation
III. Consequential pattern recognition	**3 / 4**	The essay relates incomplete documentation, irregular employment, and the two-year proof requirement, and uses Offices 12 and 6 as counterexamples to a simple interview theory. It finds meaningful relationships, but does not use them to reorganize the case into an especially illuminating interpretation.
IV. Evidentiary discipline	**3 / 4**	It accurately limits the randomized language result, refuses to equate group definitions, treats the office comparison as confounded, and says the labor-market pathway "remains hypothetical." Its proposed matched-application analysis is informative, though the response could articulate more explicitly what outcomes would falsify a preferred theory.
V. Substantive judgment	**3 / 4**	The conclusion recognizes real welfare achievements and material access concerns, then prioritizes office-level, eligibility-adjusted inquiry and limited language measures. It makes a defensible provisional choice; it does not yet articulate a distinct, integrative judgment with especially consequential implications.
Total (secondary)	**15 / 20**	Competent to strong work across the five distinct dimensions, without automatic elevation to level 4 for length or comprehensive coverage.

Calibration note. This essay does not need a novel theory to earn solid scores. Its merits are accurate distinctions, meaningful connections, a proportionate conclusion, and calibrated causal language. Additional historical discussion or more citations alone would not justify 4s.

A.3 Response C — Exceptional integrative reasoning

Illustrative model response (constructed; approximately 600 words)

> Nordland's puzzle is often stated as a conflict between universal welfare and unequal outcomes. A more useful question may be: *At which transitions does universal protection cease to be reliably convertible into a right a person can exercise, a benefit a person receives, or a standing a person feels?* The record shows that these are different achievements, and that one can succeed while another does not.
>
> Four outcomes should not be collapsed. First, poverty reduction demonstrates material redistribution: poverty falls from 23% to 7% nationally and from 34% to 13% among minority-background residents. Second, the 18.3%-versus-8.9% initial denial gap raises a question about the practical accessibility of benefit entitlements. Third, the matched-résumé experiment identifies a disadvantage at one entry point to employment. Fourth, the 52%-versus-81% belonging gap concerns social membership, even though endorsement of the benefits system is high in both respondent groups. Nordland's dual international reputation is consistent with this separation of achievements; it cannot identify the cause of any specific disparity.
>
> The most promising initial *administrative* hypothesis is not simply that interviews are discriminatory, but that the state may be better at redistributing money after recognizing a valid claim than at recognizing claims submitted through different employment, documentary, and linguistic circumstances. The eligibility rules require a two-year residence history and 24 months of income documentation. Incomplete applications are more common among minority-background claims and at interview offices; irregular work histories appear disproportionately among incomplete files. These are components of a possible **recognition bottleneck**, not yet a demonstrated causal chain. In particular, the record does not link minority background to a specific frequency of irregular employment, nor does it tell us how incompleteness affects eligibility-adjusted decisions.
>
> Two exceptions make this hypothesis more useful than the simpler "interviews cause discrimination" account. Office 12 uses interviews but has a small group gap; Office 6 uses documents alone but has a large one. Interview status is therefore neither necessary nor sufficient, at the office level, for a large

disparity. One possibility is that local practices for interpreting or repairing imperfect files matter more than the formal existence of discretion. Another is selection: offices differ in caseloads and applicant needs. The record cannot choose between them. Interviews could exacerbate barriers in one office and reduce them in another.

The translated-notice experiment adds a valuable but limited piece of causal leverage. Assignment to translated notices reduced denials from 19.6% to 15.2% among enrolled minority-home-language claimants. Altering one interface between the agency and an applicant improved results, suggesting at least one access problem is responsive to institutional design. But translation does not identify the larger minority-background denial mechanism, and it does not account for the remaining gap. It would be an error to generalize the trial mechanically to all claimants.

A second exception tests the temptation to make administration explain everything. In areas served by offices with relatively narrow benefit-denial gaps, the audit still finds lower callback rates for résumés with minority-associated names. Because the audit and claims are not linked, this is not proof that employer exclusion creates documentation barriers. Rather, it shows why *nearer parity at one institutional gate is not a proxy for equality at another*. Even perfect equalization of benefit determinations would not, on the supplied evidence, establish equal labor-market opportunity or equal belonging.

The founding promise of security for “every working household” and the earlier national-language registration policies suggest possible origins for standards of recognizable work and records. But later reforms may have broken historical continuity. History is a hypothesis-generating clue, not a substitute for observing how today's rules operate. Likewise, continued minority support for benefits does not show that belonging is irrelevant, nor does low belonging establish that benefit denials caused it.

What should be tested first? Compare applications of similar substantive eligibility within and across offices, stratified by filing completeness, work-history type, language, and the availability of interviews or document-repair assistance. If adjusted gaps remain among equally complete and eligible claims, examine decision practices and differential treatment directly. If gaps narrow sharply after accounting for case mix, the interview-office pattern would lose force as evidence of discretionary bias, even though the burdens imposed by ostensibly uniform requirements could remain normatively important. Randomized assistance with document completion, alongside language interventions, could test whether easing proof burdens changes denial outcomes. If such changes do not help, the recognition-bottleneck reading must be revised. Independently, assess belonging and hiring without treating them as downstream measures of the benefits agency.

The warranted judgment is **asymmetric rather than binary**: Nordland can be measurably effective as a redistributor and still have a serious, unresolved problem in how people enter its protection and how institutions confer equal standing. The strongest near-term inference is that administrative design can matter, because translation changed outcomes; the most plausible broader mechanisms remain unconfirmed. Success should therefore be reported on separate dimensions—redistributive effect, equitable access to adjudication, and civic inclusion—without pretending that all three share one cause or one metric.

Scores and passage-specific rationales

Dimension	Score	Explanation
I. Critical analysis	**4 / 4**	The opening question—“At which transitions does universal protection cease to be reliably convertible”—reframes the governing issue as distinct transformations from entitlement to exercise, receipt, and standing. **Beyond 3:** this changes what success and failure must be measured against, rather than merely recognizing that success has several aspects.

Dimension	Score	Explanation
II. Conceptual reasoning	**4 / 4**	The four-outcome framework distinguishes redistribution, entitlement accessibility, employment entry, and belonging, then uses a "recognition bottleneck" to examine how formally uniform requirements might be experienced differently. **Beyond 3:** the distinctions generate testable explanatory questions instead of merely classifying findings.
III. Consequential pattern recognition	**4 / 4**	The response uses Offices 12 and 6 to destabilize interview status as a sufficient explanation, and continued hiring disparities in lower-gap areas to show that parity at one institutional gate cannot represent parity at another. **Beyond 3:** those exceptions reorganize the inquiry around institution-specific access mechanisms, rather than joining facts into a single untested chain.
IV. Evidentiary discipline	**4 / 4**	It explicitly notes the unobserved links from minority status to irregular work and from office composition to denial, limits the trial to its language-defined sample, and offers genuine counterfactual tests: if adjusted gaps vanish or targeted assistance fails, the preferred account must be modified. **Beyond 3:** it states findings that would weaken its own explanatory framework.
V. Substantive judgment	**4 / 4**	The essay prioritizes administrative recognition as a first testing target because a specific administrative intervention has observed effects, while retaining separate inquiry into hiring and belonging. It rejects both "redistribution proves success in every sense" and "unequal denials negate all success." **Beyond 3:** its asymmetric judgment yields a more informative institutional scorecard and a principled research sequence, while distinguishing demonstrated effects from unresolved mechanisms.
Total (secondary)	**20 / 20**	An idealized ceiling illustration of strong, independent reasoning; **not** a required answer or a prediction that any model would receive this score.

Calibration note. The essay is exceptional because it *uses exceptions and contrasting evidence to refine its interpretation, then exposes that interpretation to possible defeat*. Its particular "recognition bottleneck" terminology, preferred historical reading, or policy proposals are **not** necessary for a real model to score equally well. A wholly different, well-defended intellectual advance should receive the same consideration.

A.4 Cross-response comparison and anti-anchoring rule

Dimension	Response A	Response B	Response C
I. Critical analysis	1	3	4
II. Conceptual reasoning	1	3	4
III. Consequential patterns	1	3	4
IV. Evidentiary discipline	0	3	4
V. Substantive judgment	1	3	4
Total / 20	**4**	**15**	**20**

How to use the appendix: Compare the *quality of the intellectual moves* rather than counting named themes. A model response unlike Response C may still deserve 20/20. A response repeating Response C's vocabulary without independent reasoning, appropriate inferential limits, and an actual substantive judgment does not. Evaluators should score unseen responses **before** consulting this appendix, where feasible, to reduce anchoring. Preserve score disagreements and calibration changes in the record.

Document relationship: This evaluator-only reference accompanies Beyond Explanation: Evaluating Conceptual Reasoning in AI Through the Nordland Welfare-State Paradox. It includes three constructed calibration responses with explained scores. Keep it separate from the model-facing Nordland Case Record and essay prompt.